

Digital Archives reflection assignment

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Instructions: Please answer the following questions and upload your answers to Brightspace. The provided word counts are a guideline to help you succeed in completing this assignment. If you choose to submit this assignment in a group, note down your group members and who worked on each part of your submission. All sources used to answer this assignment must be properly cited according to the instructions in the class syllabus. After submission, you will receive brief feedback which you can use to improve your assignment for your final portfolio.

Part 1:

Explain how Jensen's (2021) category of "digital archival literacy" addresses the distinct challenges digital archives represent for historical research. How has digitization changed historians' interactions with their sources? In your response, focus on two points that you found most thought-provoking. You may also choose to cite Jensen and Schriver (2022) in your response. (250 words)

In Jensens (2021) category of "digital archival literacy" she addresses the distinction between analogue and digital collections, which is each a way that forms the archive and effects the way historians use archives and look through sources.¹

Jensen explains, there is an inclusion and exclusion process which determines what is useful and what is not for the individual project. Only difference is, with digitalisation it is no longer the historian that selects the material amongst the lot, but a digital space, which is funded by a bigger organisation, which may select a broad vision of material in correspondence with the historians request/project.²

Another aspect, regarding the material selection when changing medium, is the economic and political aspect. Rather than selectively narrowing down the amount of material for digital archival production, it becomes a matter of interest for companies funding the digitalisation of archives. Jensen explains that shortage of funds for digitisation of projects calls for external funding with other companies. These companies become part of the selective system, determining what is available online and how "*resulting in smart looking and easy-to-use*

¹ Astrid Ølgaard Christensen Schriver & Helle Strandgaard Jensen, Arkivets Digitalisering: En ny udfordring til historisk metode?, p. 10

² Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2020): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, Media History, DOI: 10.1080/13688804.2020.1779047, p. 3

interfaces rather than transparency”³. A very good example is ‘Aarhus Arkivet’, which is sponsored by Salling-funden, where approximately 2% of its archives are digitalized, including one subpage dedicated to Salling Archive (documents on Salling) – the rest is analogue archives residing at DOKK1⁴.

Overall, as historians, it's important to understand that analogue and digital collections are different. Sources available online are very limited compared to what is available on location.⁵

Part 2

Navigate to the following page entitled “David Boder: from wire recordings to website.” <https://ranke2.uni.lu/u/boder/#c-clip.en>. Familiarize yourself with the page and watch the animation “David Boder's interview collection: from analogue to digital” to learn about Boder’s work and recent efforts to digitize his interviews.

1: Navigate to <https://iit.aviaryplatform.com/collections/231> and select one of David Boder’s interviews to analyze. Briefly provide the biographical details of the interviewee. After reading the “description” panel, discuss the provenance of the source. For example, what metadata is provided by the archive, and which historical details did the archive choose to emphasize in their written summary of the recording? (250 words)

We have selected the following interview: [David P. Boder Interviews Alfonsas Paulis](#)

Alfonsas Paulis was a Lithuanian male who spent time in concentration camps during World War 2. From the metadata provided, we do not know much about Alfonsas Paulis, but it appears that he might have spent time in both Pravieniškės, Struthof and Dachau concentration camps. His primary language was Lithuanian, with Russian and German being his secondary and tertiary languages. Paulis does not appear to have been of Jewish descent, but instead spent time in concentration camps for his work at anti-fascist newspapers.

This wire recording was made by David Boder on September 21st 1946 in a displaced persons camp for Latvians, Lithuanians and Estonians in Munich. In the recordings, David Boder makes the introduction in English, but conducts the interview with Paulis in German, who, in return, responds to the questions in his native language Lithuanian. The description does not provide a summary of the content of the recording, but it does provide a series of

³ Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2020): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, Media History, DOI: 10.1080/13688804.2020.1779047, p. 3

⁴ Aarhus Arkivet, https://www.aarhusarkivet.dk/?utm_source=homepage, visited 04/23/26 kl 20:45

⁵ Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2020): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, Media History, DOI: 10.1080/13688804.2020.1779047, p. 3

metadata on everything from time, place and subject, to recording format and the different transcribers and translators who worked on the project. All very useful, but it would have been interesting to get more biographical data about Alfonsas Paulis, such as when and where he was born and when and where he passed away, what his occupation was etc. Receiving this sort of information in the description could help historians in the process of finding relevant interviews for whatever project they might be working on.

2: Listen to a few minutes of your chosen interview. Focus on the intonations and emotions expressed by Boder and the interviewee (it's okay if you do not understand German or Russian). Based on a close listening of the speakers, contemplate how such digitized interviews might provide information absent from text-based interview transcriptions. What are the implications of using interview recordings as a historical source? You may choose to draw on Presner (2024) or information from the Ranke.2 website in your response. (250 words)

When working with and listening to oral history sources, such as David Broder's interviews with Holocaust survivors, it is important to make certain reflections. First of all, oral history presents an interesting and necessary expansion of the historical records by including otherwise marginalized voices. This is important in the process of making history more pluralistic and inclusive, hereby moving beyond elite, state-produced documents. Likewise, when working with audio interviews, certain vocal cues and emotions can be detected in the voice and speaking pattern of the interviewee, who would often be considered a 'marginalized voice'. Broder's interview with Paulis is a clear example of this, where emotion is easy to detect in the voice of Paulis, and he several times ends up speaking too fast so that Broder has to ask him to slow down. Audio interviews capture these emotions and they become very important, maybe even a sort of historical evidence, especially when studying trauma and human disasters such as the Holocaust.

However, approaching these audio interviews with care and skepticism is very important. The interviews rely heavily on the interviewee's memory, and as we know memory is subjective and constructive. People often, retrospectively, shape their stories to either make sense of their lives or present themselves positively. In audio interviews, the interviewer also reflects the source through more than just choice of question, but also through tone and reactions and even also through power dynamics, such as gender, age, class and ethnicity.

Since the interviews are based on the interviewee's memory, they often revolve around personal experiences which can be hard to check against written records. However, when they can be checked against written records, they can be useful in either confirming, complicating or contradicting already existing narratives.

This discussion is far too complex to explore in depth in just a few hundred words, but one conclusion could be that interview recordings are not inferior sources, but different sources

that demand a critical approach which treats them as both evidence of past experiences, acts of remembrance and products of their interview context.

Part 3

Compare and contrast the use of digitized historical sources in web-based databases with reborn digital sources in the archived Web. Should these sources be treated differently when conducting historical research? To complete this task, draw on your knowledge of at least two database collections discussed in class and/or your readings. In your response, please support your position using relevant literature from our course, such as Kelley (2019), Johnson (2018), Brügger (2019), and the articles mentioned in part one of this assignment. (500 words)

Digitized historical sources in web-based databases and reborn digital sources preserved in web archives have both transformed historical research, but they differ in provenance, structure, and methodological implications. As a result, while they are both important, they should be approached differently in historical analysis.

Digitized historical sources are materials that were originally analog and were later converted into digital backups, such as scanned newspapers, manuscripts, or archival records. These sources generally resemble their physical counterparts in structure and content, even if changed by interfaces, metadata, and search tools. Sean M. Kelley's discussion of the Transatlantic Slave Trade Database (Voyages) demonstrates how digitization enables large-scale quantitative analysis and new research questions, particularly by aggregating scattered archival traces into a single searchable system. At the same time, Kelley emphasizes that such databases risk privileging abstraction and numerical analysis over lived experience, potentially obscuring violence, human suffering, and contingency.⁶

Reborn digital sources, such as websites, originate as born-digital materials, but are transformed through the process of web archiving. According to Niels Brügger, the archived web is not a stable copy of an original but a unique, incomplete, and inconsistent reconstruction shaped by strategies, technical constraints, and archival decisions.⁷ Unlike digitized sources, reborn digital materials lack a fixed original to verify accuracy, and links, layout, and content may reflect moments drawn from different times. This makes the archived web less transparent but also analytically rich, as we as historians can not only study content but also structure, link networks, and patterns of change over time.

⁶ Sean M. Kelley, 'DB or Not DB: Writing the History of the Slave Trade to North America in the Era of the Database,' *History Compass* 17, no. 5 (2019).

⁷ Niels Brügger, 'Understanding the Archived Web as a Historical Source,' in *The SAGE Handbook of Web History* (London: SAGE, 2019).

The ethical and interpretive stakes of these differences are highlighted by Jessica Marie Johnson's critique of data histories of slavery. Johnson argues that digital projects, especially databases, often reinscribe the logics of commodification installed in the original archival record by reducing Black lives to data points.⁸ This critique applies to both digitized databases and web archives, but the risk is intensified when we treat digital sources as neutral representations rather than as constructed artifacts. Johnson calls for methodological approaches that emphasize power, violence, and the afterlives of slavery in digital infrastructures themselves.

Taken together, these perspectives suggest that digitized and reborn digital sources should indeed be treated differently in historical research. Digitized databases often invite source criticism similar to traditional archives, focused on selection, categorization, and quantitative bias. Reborn digital sources require an additional layer of critique that accounts for digitality itself: archiving methods, fragmentation, and interface effects. At the same time, neither type of source should be used uncritically. Both demand reflection and methodologies that balance scale with context and data with narrative.

Ultimately, the distinction is not about privileging one type of digital source over another, but about recognizing their different conditions. Treating digitized and reborn digital sources as the same, could result in undermining their complexities. Treating them differently, by contrast, allows us as historians to use their strengths while remembering their limitations and ethical implications.

⁸ Jessica Marie Johnson, 'Markup Bodies: Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroads,' *Social Text* 36, no. 4 (2018).